

## Construction project details

- What are the details of the construction project? **See attached application submitted to MSBA [here](#).**
- What parts of the facility will be modified as a part of the construction project? **The roof over the classroom section and the roof over the gymnasium section. 104,000 sf**
- If the project includes modification of any parts of the facility in addition to the roof, why? Why can't the project be smaller in scope to reduce cost? i.e. What are we getting from this project that we can't achieve with \$8M or \$6M? **This project is replacing two of the three roof sections. All three sections of the roof have significant leaks.**
- Why does the project need to happen within the timeline of a single summer? i.e. Why can't the project be divided into phases to mitigate cost? **The project and timeline have been submitted to the MSBA. Changing the timeline would cause us to miss the Oct 29 MSBA vote. We have 14 months from the 10/30/24 date that we were invited into the MSBA program to have the project voted on at a MSBA Board of Directors meeting. If we don't meet that timeline we could be removed from the program and would have to reapply.**
- Does the project require compliance with Architectural Access Board regulation 521 CMR Section 3.3.2? "If the cost of the proposed work is greater than 30% of the full and fair cash value of the existing building, the entire building is required to comply with 521 CMR." **No, the project cost does not exceed 30% of the building's assessed value.**
- Why aren't we building more than 1K sq ft of solar? **The roof structure won't support a ballasted PV system. That would normally be the preferred approach for a roof like this. A dunnage system to make this portion of the roof solar ready is very expensive. It's about \$100,000 for 1000sf. Without a definite timeline to add solar to the roof we thought it would be better to try to keep the cost of the project down. The MSBA requires a portion of the roof to be made solar ready.**
- Why does the project include replacing internal roof drainage with perimeter drainage? **The internal roof drains have been a source of leaks in the building. The roof is pitched toward the roof drains in the middle of the roof. As the drains fail they allow water to travel through the building causing leaks in several spots. The cast iron pipes that run through the building that are connected to the roof drains will also begin to crack. Replacement of the pipes would require demolition work and be very expensive. Replacing the pipes is not included in any of the roof options.**
- How does the reason for this design justify the cost of tapered insulation to pitch the roof to the perimeter? What are the long-term risks and maintenance costs of the pitched roof design? **The tapered insulation removes the need for the roof drain system. The pipes that connect to the roof drains run throughout the building. Repairing or replacing the pipes when they begin to fail would require demolition of walls and would be expensive**

and disruptive. The pitched roof allows us to keep the water outside of the building rather than having it run through a piping system that has the potential for leaking. There are no long term risks that we are aware of and no additional maintenance costs other than cleaning the gutters which could be handled by our staff.

- What would be the consequences of leaving the roof unrepaired? **There are short-term and long term consequences, persistent leaks that can cause deterioration, ceiling collapsing, mold and mildew growth, poor air quality, slip hazards, electrical risks, closure of spaces, increased cost for a larger repair, possible insurance issues, potential lawsuits for any health risks etc.**

## MSBA

- What are the MSBA reimbursement program requirements? **This information can be found [here](#).**
- Given that the MSBA program will require that ARMS be used for educational purposes for 20 years, what will qualify as an "educational purpose"? **MSBA stated it is "expected" that it would be in service for a minimum of 20 years. When speaking with MSBA directly they would not go into "what if" scenarios. If we chose to do something different at any point in time we must contact them prior to any decision making. They would determine at that time if they needed to recapture any funding.**
- Would the MSBA be willing to reimburse the project in multi-year phases if construction can take place in phases to mitigate costs? **The project and timeline have been submitted to the MSBA. Changing the timeline would cause us to miss the Oct 29 MSBA vote. We have 14 months from the 10/30/24 date that we were invited into the MSBA program to have the project voted on at a MSBA Board of Directors meeting. If we don't meet that timeline we could be removed from the program and would have to reapply.**
- Why are we building any solar at all? i.e. If solar readiness is required, but operational solar is not required, could we build the \$70K dunnage but omit the electrical work from the project? What impact would this have on cost? **MSBA requires the roof to have some aspect of being solar ready, this is a new requirement of MSBA.**
- What is the history of the district's plan to rebuild the roof? **The district has been making repairs to the roof as needed but they are ineffective, the roof is in terrible shape. The roof over the classroom wing and Gymnasium wing was replaced in 1994 with a PVC roof system that carried a 15 year warranty. The Auditorium roof was replaced in 1999 with a PVC roof system that also carried a 15 year warranty.**
- Why didn't the MSBA authorize the project after the district approved the 2019 debt authorization? **The roof did not qualify every year for MSBA, but now it does.**

## Reducing the number of facilities

- Why aren't we consolidating the middle school into the high school facility?
- In 2018-2019, JCJ Architecture conducted a [Regional Master Facilities Use Study](#) that included design options for, "Incorporating all of the ARMS students (Grades 7 and 8) into the existing ARHS facility (Grades 9 through 12) to create a Regional Middle/High School for Grades 7 through 12 and recommend alternative uses for the resultant available in the existing ARMS facility." What happened that caused the district and the towns to not proceed with those design options? **We are unsure of the history of what the district or towns decided. However, in the plan it required additions to the HS in order to consolidate, which were ranging from \$33.6M-\$54.7M according to executive summary in report on page 11. Keep in mind these were pre-covid figures. At this time, we do not have the funding to be able to consolidate, in addition with the 6th graders moving into the middle school, space for consolidation of HS/MS would need to be considered and a new study completed.**
- Assuming MSBA approval of the project at the end of October, what would happen to the relationship between our school district and the MSBA if the district or towns decide not to pursue the roof replacement project, so we could instead pursue a project to consolidate the middle school with the high school? **It's unknown how it would affect our standing with the MSBA. The school has been applying for the MSBA grant program since 2019 and was finally accepted in 2024. Future projects aren't guaranteed to be accepted. If they were approved we would have no control as to how many years it would take.**

## Capital planning

- How are capital expenses assessed according to the regional agreement? **Per the regional agreement this is based on EQV at the time the debt is authorized. In this case 2024 EQV.**
- How does the cost of the project in 2025 dollars and construction market conditions compare to estimated cost in 2019 dollars and construction market conditions, when the first debt authorization was approved? **Predecessors prior estimate was \$6M.**
- How was the \$400,000 used from the first debt authorization? **Patching repairs on existing work. In addition, we have design costs that are currently being charged here until the new funding is approved.**
- In the FY26 budget book for ARPS, the FY2026 capital budget for the middle school includes a total of \$220,000 in costs for the walk-in cooler & freezer, fire safety system upgrade, west parking lot repaving, and theater curtains. Why doesn't it include the ARMS roof? **The \$3M debt authorization was already included in the capital planning and debt assessment projections.**
- In the FY26 budget book, the capital plan 10-year forecast includes a "Replace Roofs" line for ARMS that forecasts \$1.5M in FY29. Was that forecast of cost

meant to set expectations for the entire project cost, or just the district's share of the project cost after MSBA reimbursement? **The debt authorization of \$3M was already included in the debt assessment. It is unclear why predecessors only included half of that in the forecast number, but most importantly the \$3M was already built into the debt assessment schedule for those calculations.**

- How does the district justify asking for a roof replacement project two years earlier than the forecast at 3x the forecasted cost to the district? **We have applied every year for the MSBA accelerated repair program. It was finally accepted, and the roof is in dire need.**
- The budget book states, "On March 1, 2010 the Amherst-Pelham Regional School committee adopted a policy for developing a formal capital needs planning process" and, "The Regional Capital Planning Committee, comprised of members of the Regional Budget and Finance Subcommittee, the Director of Finance, and the Director of Operations, is charged with annually developing a ten-year capital improvement plan, including the upcoming annual capital improvement budget and a nine-year projection of capital needs and expenditures which details the estimated cost, description, and anticipated funding sources for capital projects." Given this, what was the Regional School Committee's involvement in capital planning for the current roof project? **The budget and audit subcommittee (of RSC) has approved a liaison to sit in on district capital meetings.**
- What is the timeline and amount of other capital expenditure expected from capital planning? i.e. Will there be other big surprises? **The MS roof is top priority. We are in preparation of preparing long term capital needs.**
- Is the [ARPS Ten Year Capital Plan \(Proposed January 31, 2023\)](#) the currently adopted capital plan? Are there other capital planning documents outside of the budget book? **No, the district is in the process of re-vamping after turnover in both financial and facilities leadership.**
- The Ten Year Capital Plan document (proposed January 31, 2023) identifies the high school roof as also being in need of replacement, also with assistance from the MSBA accelerated repair program, but with only "medium" urgency. What does medium urgency mean? When does medium urgency become high urgency? **The high school roof has had fewer leaks than the middle school roof.**
- The FY26 budget book capital plan forecasts \$50K in FY27 and \$5M in FY30 for the high school roof replacement. Are those forecasts still accurate? Do they represent total project cost or expected cost after MSBA reimbursement? **The asphalt shingle section of the roof above the English wing is deteriorating and needs to be replaced. There was a study done in 2024 that estimates the cost of replacing it at \$540,000. That should be done in 2027. The thermoplastic membrane roof is also 29 years old and has exceeded its life expectancy. It is likely to be more than \$5 million in terms of total project cost (excluding MSBA), we will be revising in comparison to what we know the project cost will be for the Middle School Roof.**

- The FY26 budget book capital plan forecasts \$20K every other year for asbestos management and abatement. What does the district do with these costs? Will the roof replacement projects reduce or eliminate the need for asbestos management and abatement? **This money is for inspections, testing, and abatement of damaged asbestos. Federal regulations require regular inspections and testing in buildings that contain asbestos. In addition, any repairs that have to take place where there is suspected asbestos must first go through an expensive abatement process that must be contracted out. The roof replacement could reduce some of the expense by eliminating the water damage that the roof is causing.**

## District budgeting

- What do we expect will be the terms of financing this debt? How long, at what interest rate, and are there any risks or contingency costs that we need to be aware of? **This is something we are discussing with our financial advisors. According to the region agreement it cannot be longer than 20 years. It could be 5, 10, 15, 20. Interest rate is not yet known. Contingency costs were already built into the budget.**
- How much debt service will we add to the annual budget? **We are currently reviewing the best financial options for the district and length to borrow. The estimated amount for Leverett's share is \$412k plus interest, approximately \$155k plus interest above the \$3M only.**
- How will the district reduce operating costs to compensate for the added debt service cost of the roof? **The district is continually evaluating operating expenses to identify cost-saving opportunities and improve overall efficiency. For example, in our most recent transportation bid, we included previously unbundled services such as out-of-district transportation, McKinney-Vento transportation, and other specialized transportation needs. By consolidating these services into a single bid, we were able to achieve economies of scale and lower our overall transportation costs had we not bundled as our previous contract. Looking ahead, our operations team is actively collaborating on the development of the FY27 budget with a focused effort on identifying additional efficiencies to determine where further cost reductions can be made.**
- The Ten Year Capital Plan document (proposed January 31, 2023) states under fiscal impact for the middle school roof replacement, "Bringing roof insulation up to current code will reduce energy usage and thus operating costs." Do we have an estimate of operating cost savings? **At this time, we do not have a finalized estimate of the specific operating cost savings. However, it is well established that bringing roof insulation up to current energy code standards results in reduced heat loss and improved building efficiency. This leads to measurable savings in heating and cooling costs over time.**

- Does the ARPS district expect to request a Prop 2 1/2 override for FY27?  
**Unknown at this time.**